

The Ballad of Thorn Wraith, Sung Beside a Banked Hearth

O hush the latch and dim the flame, Let no bright ember climb; For there is one who walks unseen Across the fields of time. Not flesh, nor fog, nor common shade, Nor wraith that mourns the dead— But **Thorn Wraith**, with a starving heart, Where sleeping thoughts are fed.

“Sleep not deep, and wake not wide, Bar the door on either side; For what comes near and does not speak May wear your dream upon its hide.”

It enters where the eyelids close, Where silver rivers run, Where little hopes like candles burn Before the rising sun. It drinks the road beneath the feet, The face one longs to see; It takes the word that might have healed And leaves the tongue to flee.

For **Thorn Wraith is a dream-feeder**, And draws its nature from The **invasion and consumption of dreams**, Wherever sleep has come. It does not hunger as beasts do, Nor tear as wolves might tear; It waits beside the inward door And finds the sleeper there.

A mother heard a child’s soft laugh— Or so the dark seemed kind— Then watched the laughter lose its shape And vanish from her mind. A soldier dreamed of open skies, A beggar dreamed of bread; The Thorn Wraith drank the shining parts And left the dreamer dread.

“Sleep not deep, and wake not wide, Bar the door on either side; For what comes near and does not speak May wear your dream upon its hide.”

Its form is ghostly, pale and thin, Yet never wholly bare; For thorn-like shapes are threaded through Its outline in the air. Each barb appears, then fades away, Like briars seen through rain; A cruel and insubstantial shape, Too near to name, too plain.

It leans as close as whispered prayer, It knows the pulse, the breath; It haunts the mind with patient care, A patience born of death. Yet death is not the name for it— The waking world knows why: It belongs as much to terror’s bed As to the morning sky.

So if you wake with frost within And thorns behind your eyes, Do not say, “It was but dreaming,” Nor trust the light that lies. Keep one small thought that it has missed, Guard one unbroken spark; For Thorn Wraith feeds upon the dream That first gives shape to dark.

“Sleep not deep, and wake not wide, Bar the door on either side; For what comes near and does not speak May wear your dream upon its hide.”